economies also recovered. The Czech Republic (with solid banks and relatively strong manufacturing), Slovenia and Slovakia managed the crisis a bit better.

It is important to note these differences, but also the fact that Central Europe still performed better than the European South. And it was on the latter that the eyes of Central Europeans were focused at the time, on Greece in particular. (There were some degrading statements about Greece also by Central Europeans and, in 2015, the Slovenian finance minister allegedly suggested that Greece should leave the Eurozone – imagine the furore by Greeks, being told something like that by an Eastern European.) They were carefully looking at the attitude of Europe's north to these countries, which was very telling: concrete gestures of solidarity with Greece (and other countries in financial distress) eventually came, but after some wrangling and dragging of feet, and at a high price. The message that has been taken by Eastern Europeans was that there were limits to European solidarity.

In the meantime and in the shadow of European economic woes, Putin intervened militarily in Georgia in 2008, effectively enabling the creation of two breakaway entities within that country. The Russian leader calculated well that he could easily go that far, and his hopes were confirmed by only mild reactions from the West. But this only further increased the concerns of many Central Europeans.

Soon after, there was again turmoil in the Arab world. In December 2010 the so-called Arab Spring set off in Tunisia and, in early 2011, protests erupted across the Middle East, triggered by a mixture of autocratic rule and oppression, corruption, and the dire economic and social situation. (Religion played a role too – something that continues to be under-explored, perhaps simply because Western secularism has made its citizens ignorant about religion.) In a handful of countries (Tunisia, Morocco, Algeria) these protests resulted in minor concessions by those in power. But in some the consequences were devastating. In Egypt, Hosni Mubarak was toppled and the leader of the Muslim Brotherhood, Mohamed Morsi, became President in 2012 before he was removed by the army the following year. In Libya, another tyrant, Muammar Gadaffi was overthrown with indirect assistance from a France-initiated, multinational UN force, but today the country is still divided into areas controlled by different factions and serves as a